WrestleCraft: game review and the road to A+

Oct 21, 2026 · @Bill

The verdict

WrestleCraft is a B game with A+ bones: the deepest booking simulation I have seen in the genre, a charming paper-diorama broadcast, and a test suite most indie games never get. What holds it back is not missing features. It is that the game is too easy to coast, its numbers tell the player conflicting stories, and the screens still show their seams. The fastest route to A+ is to stop adding systems for a while and make the existing ones bite, read clearly and feel finished.

Area	Grade	In one line
Depth of simulation	A	102 engine systems that feed each other through people, memory and money.
Stability and tests	A-	All 50 headless tests and 4 of 5 browser suites pass; zero errors or bad numbers in two-year runs.
The broadcast	A-	The live show with calls from the gorilla position is the game's best idea, and it looks great.
Challenge and balance	C	On Suggest a card alone, nobody was fired in 30 two-year runs, and most bookers were handed the company.
Feedback and clarity	C+	Grades say "good show" while popularity and cash fall; the player cannot tell which number matters.
First hour	C	Busywork tasks, a C grade on the first show from the game's own suggestion, a letter in the wrong art style.
Polish	B-	Cut-off text on most pages, a few unreadable labels, camera clipping on the broadcast.
Audio	D	Synthesised music and blips only; no crowd, no bell, no pops.

Area	Grade	In one line
Code health	B-	Clear rules and hooks, but 1.3 MB of dense ES5 in one scope with functions rewritten up to six times.
Ready for Steam	C	Desktop wrapper untested, one save slot, no options for resolution or audio mix, legal questions open.

How I reviewed it

This is version 0.88 at commit a6ecb99 on main (20 October), read and run in a fresh cloud machine. Nothing in the repo was changed.

- **Read:** CLAUDE.md, NEXT.md, the roadmap, the earlier reviews in docs/plans, and the core of the engine (core, match, live show, week, booking power, owner, tasks) plus the store, the broadcast and the desk on the interface side.
- **Built and tested:** the build is reproducible (it matches the committed dist byte for byte). The type-check is clean. All 50 headless tests pass. Browser suites: journey, calls, desk and scene pass; onescreen fails one check at tablet size.
- **Played:** a fresh game as a new player would see it (default settings, the parody world, EWE) at 1920x1080 and at Steam Deck size, three weeks with suggested cards, screenshots of every main page and the broadcast with scenes on.
- **Balance runs:** every company in the parody world, three seeds each, 96 weeks, booking only with Suggest a card and taking the safe answer to every call. That is 30 two-year careers.

On the open issue from the earlier session: the only broadcast check I saw fail is onescreen's "every answer is on screen" for a run-in call at 1024x768. That size is no longer a target (rule 0), so the test should drop tablet mode rather than the game change. The debut checks in the scene test passed.

Gameplay

The week loop (desk, backstage, book, air the show, after the show) is sound, and every phase hands the next a problem, as the design asks. The trouble is weight: too many systems speak at once, and the ones that should bite do not.

What works

- **The gorilla position.** Calls that are caused, never random (a rival at the curtain, the owner wanting a favourite to win, a hot crowd begging for the title change), each with costs people remember. This is the hook that sets the game apart.
- **People with memory.** Backstage reads like a locker room: real heat at separate tables in catering, two wrestlers who do not click, a veteran staying late with a kid. The relationship matrix and `youRemember()` make choices stick.
- **Living storylines.** Heat and freshness instead of fixed lengths is a better model than most games in the genre use.
- **Writing.** Commentary, the dirt sheet and the chat room are varied, true to the game state, and often funny.

What does not

- **You do not decide who wins.** Unless you spend booking power, the winner is a weighted roll (`winOdds()` in src/10-match.js). Calling the favourite costs 1 point, an underdog 2 or 3, and a show refills about 3 to 5. In every booking game players know, the booker's first power is the finish. Here it is rationed, and the README even promises "pick who wins". This is the biggest design question in the game.
- **Three shows a week for the starting company.** EWE airs three weekly shows, so every week is three cards to book and three broadcasts. Even skipping each segment, a show took about two minutes in my run; at the default TV pace it is longer. The "one more turn" pull gets heavy fast.
- **Busywork in week one.** The first desk has three must-do tasks: pick a play-by-play voice, pick a colour voice, and look at sponsors. The commentary team already exists in the data; the game should seat them and let the player change it later.
- **Too many voices.** The desk, tasks, notification bar, inbox, writers, road agent, feed and after-show page all compete. The earlier review asked for a cap on interruptions a week; it is still not there.
- **No pressure to stay sharp.** See Balance: the game plays itself for two years without getting you fired.

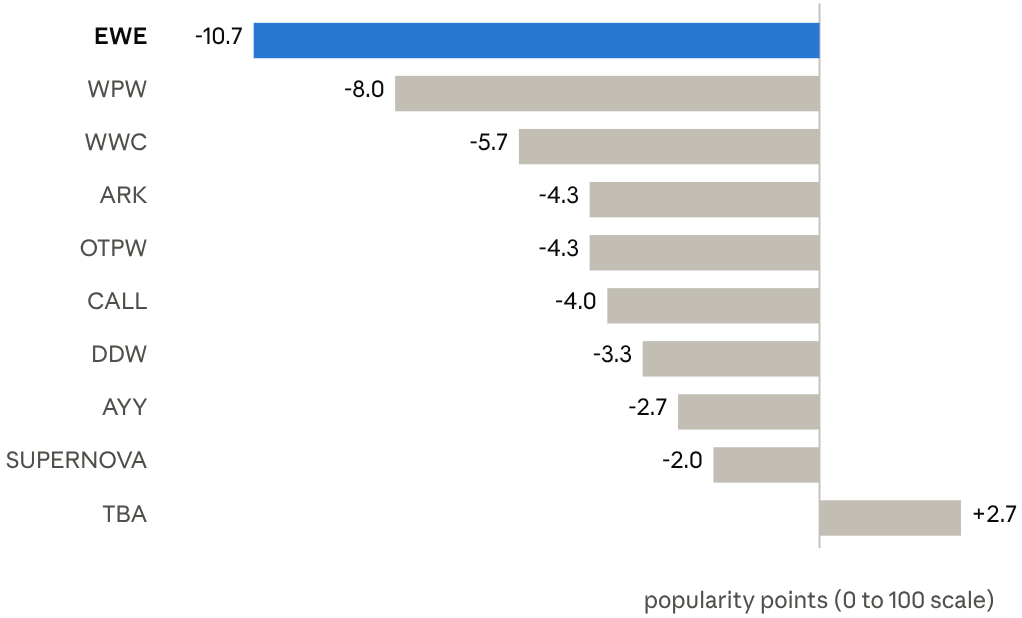
Balance

A booker who only presses Suggest a card is never fired, is usually handed the company, and watches it shrink while being told the shows were good. That is three problems in one: no fail state, no clear goal, and feedback that contradicts itself.

- **Nobody was fired in 30 two-year runs.** Owner trust rose to 76 to 100 in about 25 of them, and the owner then handed over the keys (the handover needs trust 80, booker level 5 and week 30). After that, firing is off the table for good. Two runs went bankrupt (EWE in week 91, WPW in week 82), both while the owner was delighted.
- **Suggest a card is not "flat, around a C".** Ryan's roadmap asks for that. Across 4,722 suggested shows: 30% graded A- or better, 37% in the B band, 30% in the C band and 5% D or F. The median show is a B.
- **Good grades, shrinking company.** The grade measures a show against its own crowd, while popularity and cash measure the business, and they disagree. EWE's suggested shows were mostly B and A, yet it lost 9 to 13 popularity and $42M to $78M in two years.
- **The starting company bleeds money.** EWE's three weekly shows each run about $1M a week in the red before the big event. A new player will go broke without knowing why.

On Suggest a card alone, nine of ten companies lose popularity over two years

Popularity change after 96 weeks, average of 3 seeds. 9 of 10 fall; EWE, the starting company, falls most.



30 headless runs of engine.js v0.88, parody world, seeds 3, 11 and 29, Suggest a card every show, safe answer to every call

The fix is not "make it harder". It is to tie the owner's trust, the grade and the money to one clear yearly goal, and to make a coasting booker feel it within a season.

Polish and presentation

The workbench look is distinctive and the diorama broadcast is genuinely charming: entrances, near falls with a referee in frame, a feed of fans posting as the show goes. The rest of the screens are close but not finished.

- **Cut-off text everywhere.** At 1920x1080 the desk alone truncates the building name, the hometown line, the road list, the market and the tasks note ("A show cannot run until those marked ! are done or left for..."). The roster cuts the Holds column and the buttons at the foot of the wrestler's file. The earlier review flagged this; `fits()` checks height, not ellipses.
- **Unreadable labels.** On the sign-off card the Attendance and TV viewers values and the best-match stars are near-white on cream. The achievement toast prints white text on yellow. The storylines title bar draws "Building" over the feud's name.
- **One page in the old style.** The owner's letter, the first thing a new player reads, is still green-on-black terminal text with a broken box-drawing border, against rule 2a.
- **Week one says nothing on the heat chart.** Storylines shows twelve empty teal weeks even though feuds have been running for seven.
- **Bars without meaning.** Crowd, Mood and Body on the roster are nearly all full green, and the overall rating sits between 82 and 91 for the whole top of a 75-person roster.
- **Broadcast camera.** A close-up put the camera inside the referee, who fills the top-left of the frame.
- **Audio is the weakest part.** A synthesised rock band and UI blips. No crowd bed, no pops for entrances, no bell, no kick-out roar. For a game whose centrepiece is a live show, sound is half the experience.
- **Load time.** A new game takes about 10 seconds in the browser before the desk appears (calibration runs sample shows for every company). It needs a progress card, not a frozen screen.

The first hour, as a new player sees it: a terminal-style letter, then a desk with three must-do chores, then a red-hot crowd expecting four-and-a-half-star matches, then the game's own Suggest a card graded C, "Lost the crowd", with the owner's trust down. The depth is there, but the first impression is failure and admin.

Bugs found

No crashes, no console errors (one missing favicon) and no bad numbers in any run. What I found is presentation and edge cases, worst first.

Bug	Where	Evidence	Severity
A failed save is never reported: `save()` returns `!!db || true`, and the IndexedDB write swallows its errors	app/src/store.ts, `save()` and `idbPut()`	Read in code	High for Steam
Sign-off card values (attendance, viewers, best match) are near-invisible	app/src/screens/booking/Live.tsx:103	Screenshot at 1920x1080	Medium
Achievement toast is white text on yellow	Toast over the after-show page	Screenshot	Medium
Owner's letter in the retired terminal look, border characters out of line	WelcomeWindow in app/src/screens/office/Windows.tsx	Screenshot	Medium
Dirt sheet prints "Edited by ·" with no name when the columnist's name has no " of "	app/src/screens/net/Sheet.tsx, the `ed` split	Screenshot	Low
Storylines window title draws "Building" over the feud name	Storylines, picked feud window	Screenshot	Low

Bug	Where	Evidence	Severity
Broadcast header stays at "0:00 into the show" during the first match while the feed shows 0:07	Live.tsx, the ON AIR bar	Screenshots 7 s apart	Low
Close-up camera clips through the referee	kit/diorama3d.ts camera placement	Screenshot	Low
Escape does not close the owner's letter; only the button does	WelcomeWindow	Playwright run	Low
onescreen test still runs tablet size and fails there	app/tests/onescreen.js	Test log	Test only

Two content flags for Ryan rather than bugs: a WPW wrestler billed as "The Black Russian" reads as an ethnic gimmick on the dirt sheet, and the parody companies' owners and wrestlers are recognisable by design (see Legal).

Code quality

The architecture is disciplined: the engine owns plain-JSON state, the screens never write to it, everything is seeded and repeatable, and hook lists let systems plug in. The cost is readability, and it is growing faster than the game.

- **Size and density.** 102 engine files, 14,538 lines, 1.3 MB: about 91 characters a line on average, 208 lines over 300 characters, three over 1,000. The interface adds 13,000 lines with 338 lines over 300.
- **Functions rewritten in place.** Later files replace earlier functions (`E.validate` is wrapped six times, `E.runPlayerShow` three) and 21 files use the wrap pattern. To know what a function does you must read every file that sorts after it. A `test-buildorder.js` check guards the order, which is good, but it is a symptom.
- **A "99-" pile.** 33 files are named 99-something so they load last. File order has become the dependency system.

- **Weak typing at the seam.** The interface is strict TypeScript, but `noImplicitAny` is off and there are 740 `: any` annotations; the engine is untyped ES5.
- **Tests check fit, not legibility.** The suites are a real strength (50 headless, about 40 browser), but they passed while labels were invisible and text was cut off. Tests also run with broadcast pictures off by default, so the renderer is lightly covered.
- **Docs are thorough but huge.** CLAUDE.md is 77 KB and TASKS.md 124 KB. They work for Claude sessions; a human contributor would struggle.

No big rewrite is needed. Turn the wraps into proper hooks as files are touched, split files over 500 lines, and add a contrast and ellipsis check to `fits()`.

Legal and release risks

The repository is public, the game is meant to be sold on Steam, and the default world parodies real people closely. That combination needs a lawyer's read before launch, not after.

- **The parody world is the default.** Companies map one-to-one onto real promotions, the starting company's owner is a recognisable real executive, and since 20 October the EWE and WWC rosters are "dressed after the people they parody" in their real colours and signature gear, with their real moves under joke names. That is closer to likeness than changed names alone. The public-domain world is safer as the default for a commercial launch, with the parody world as a free download or an opt-in.
- **Who-is-who notes are still in git history** (decisions-needed.md says so), and the repo is public. Anyone can read them today.
- **No licence** is chosen, so the code is all rights reserved by default, while the repo is public.
- **Steam readiness:** the Electron wrapper and every Steam call are untested; saves live in IndexedDB with one slot and no save files the player can see or back up; there is no Steam Cloud, no settings for resolution, window mode or audio levels, and no credits screen.

The plan to A+

Freeze new systems until phase 3 is done. Every step below makes something that already exists bite harder, read clearer or feel finished. In order of impact:

Phase 1: Make the game a game (balance and goals)

1. **Give the booker the finish.** Picking a winner is free. Booking power buys the extras instead: a protected finish, a run-in, a surprise, a title change against the odds the locker room will resent. The cost of a bad call moves to people and the crowd, where the game's strength is. If Ryan keeps rationing, at least make calling the favourite free.
2. **One yearly goal from the owner,** stated in the letter and on the desk: a popularity target, a cash floor and one story beat ("make a new world champion by the flagship"). Owner trust follows that goal, not just weekly grades.
3. **Make coasting fail.** Retune so Suggest a card lands around a C as the roadmap says, and so a booker who only suggests is in danger by the end of year one. Raise the handover bar (two years, the yearly goal met twice).
4. **Make the numbers agree.** If shows grade B and A, popularity should rise. Either fix the drift or show the player why it falls ("rivals are winning the diehards", "three shows a week is burning the crowd out").
5. **Fix the starting company's money.** EWE should not lose $1M a show by default. A new player's first year should be winnable with a few good choices.
6. **A balance test in CI** with targets per company model (fired rate, bankrupt rate, popularity drift, grade spread on Suggest), three seeds, two years. My probe script is a starting point.

Phase 2: The first hour

7. **Seat the commentary team and skip sponsor admin** in week one; the first desk has one task, "Book your first show".
8. **A guided first month** (the Timekeeper plan already written in EWF-road-to-a-plus.pdf). The first show is set up to succeed: a crowd that expects a solid show, not a red-hot one.
9. **Start smaller.** Default to one weekly show for a first game, or let EWE's three shows unlock over the first months.
10. **Restyle the owner's letter** in the workbench look and show a progress card during the 10-second start.

Phase 3: Finish the screens

11. **Zero cut-off text.** Add an ellipsis check and a contrast check to `fits()`, then fix every page it flags at 1280x800 and 1920x1080.
12. **Fix the invisible and overlapping labels** listed under Bugs.
13. **A cap on interruptions:** rank matters and calls, show the top three a week, let the rest resolve on their own.

14. **Roster bars that differ:** words and a wider colour range, so a glance tells you who is tired or unhappy.
15. **Pace the broadcast:** a "key moments" pace that airs a weekly show in under a minute, and full pace for big events.

Phase 4: Sound and feel

16. **Real audio:** crowd beds that follow the crowd meter, entrance pops, the bell, near-fall roars, a kick-out gasp. Relax rule 2 for the Steam build, where shipped audio files cost nothing.
17. **Camera rules** for the diorama so close-ups never clip through figures, and a quality setting for the Deck.

Phase 5: Ship it

18. **Saves for a PC game:** several named slots, files the player can see and back up, Steam Cloud, and a visible error when a save fails.
19. **Test the wrapper** on Windows and a Steam Deck, and the Steam achievement calls against app 480.
20. **Legal:** a lawyer's read of the parody world; make the public-domain world the default for the paid release; scrub the parody notes from git history or make the repo private; pick a licence.
21. **Options a PC player expects:** resolution, window mode, text size, audio levels, key rebinding.

Alongside, every week: turn one wrap into a proper hook, split one file over 500 lines, and keep the test suite green on both worlds.

Decisions for Ryan and Bill

These change what the game is, so they are yours to call. My recommendation is in bold.

1. **Who picks the winner?** Keep booking power as the price of a finish, or **make picking the winner free and charge for the extras.**
2. **How good should Suggest a card be? A C, as the roadmap says,** or a B as it plays today.
3. **Which world ships by default on Steam?** The parody world, or **the public-domain world, with parody as an option** after a lawyer's read.
4. **The repo:** keep it public, or **make it private and scrub the parody notes from history** before release.
5. **Licence: pick one now** (all rights reserved is the simplest for a paid game).

6. **New systems:** keep adding, or **pause new systems until phases 1 to 3 are done.**
7. **Starting size:** keep EWE's three weekly shows, or **start a first game with one show** and grow.
8. **The tablet test:** fix the broadcast fit at 1024x768, or **drop tablet from the onescreen suite** since the game ships on PC and Deck.

Nothing in the repo was changed for this review. Say which phase to start on and I will open a branch for it.